	Value given in balance sheet	Real value (in the estimation of the Madurai collector)
SS *Gallia*	3,42,652-6-0	2,70,000 (£ 18,000)
SS *Lawoe*	2,26,217-5-0	1,50,000 (£ 10,000)
Miranda	24,784	10,500 (£ 700)
Total	**5,93,654-3-0**	**4,30,500**

There was therefore a discrepancy of Rs 1,63,000. Though a year had elapsed since their purchase, he wondered why no depreciation had been charged. Regarding the claim of Rs 60,584-15-4 as ‘preliminary expenses’, he said, it was difficult to imagine what these expenses were. In the typical language of those who sling mud, he added, ‘The general opinion of those who have watched the company is that, in this item and the largely overstated value of the vessels is to be found the cause of the sudden rise of V.O. Chidambaram Pillai from poverty to affluence.’ Unable to substantiate a specific charge, he took recourse to ‘general opinion’. Given that a body of CID police and spies had shadowed VOC and his associates across presidencies since early 1906, one really wonders how and where the district collector gathered information which they had not been able to collect. After the issuance of new shares following the annual shareholders’ meeting, the capital stood at Rs 7.5 lakh with a loan of Rs 4.5 lakh being taken—which had ‘all gone’, he said.

To return to the annual general body meeting of 3 July, what transpired there did not meet the government’s desire—the collapse of the company. The remark of the district superintendent of police, ‘I do not think that the meeting was a representative one or that the proposals are serious’ indicates this disappointment.[32] Wynch, for his part, appended these heartless comments in his forwarding letter: ‘The Directors dare not suggest liquidation, and the company will go on so long as they can beg, borrow, or cajole money out of people to pay coal bills and wages of crew. The only asset the company possesses is the sentiment, to which they have hitherto